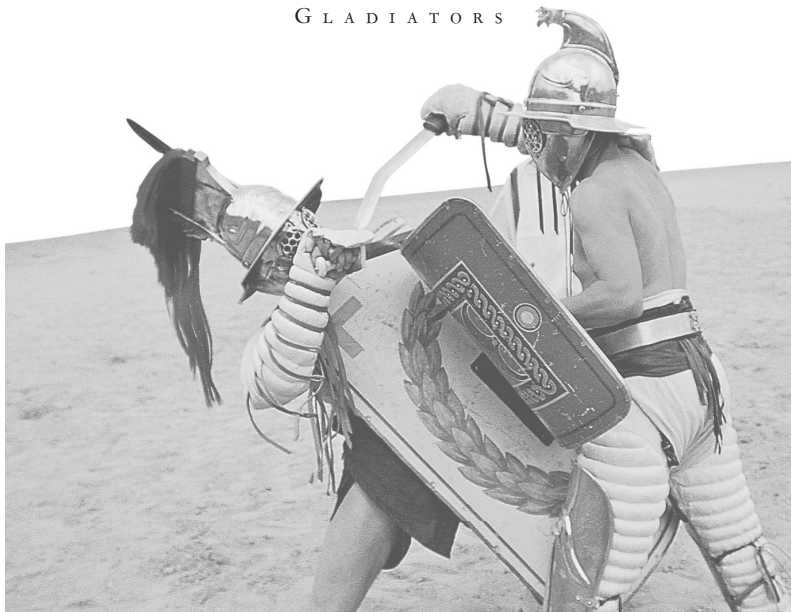




Thumbs up or thumbs down?

Here's a puzzle that continues to baffle historians. No one can be totally certain if "thumbs down" really was the sign of the death sentence. Some experts think we've got it dead wrong. They say "thumbs down" meant "put the sword

A *THRAEX* STABS AT A *MURMILLO*'S NECK WITH HIS CURVED SWORD. MOST GLADIATORS WHO DIED IN THE ARENA WERE AGED BETWEEN 18 AND 25.

away," as if sliding it back into its scabbard, whereas "thumbs up" meant "stick it in them." The fact is, we just don't know. The prevailing view seems to be that the Romans used the "thumbs down" gesture when they wanted a fighter to die—which just shows how easy it is to believe so-called "facts" that might, in fact, turn out to be fiction!

WINNING GLADIATORS DID A LAP OF HONOR AROUND THE ARENA, WEARING LAUREL WREATHS AND WAVING LAUREL BRANCHES IN THE AIR.

Winners and losers

By the end of a contest, the floor of the arena was drenched in blood.